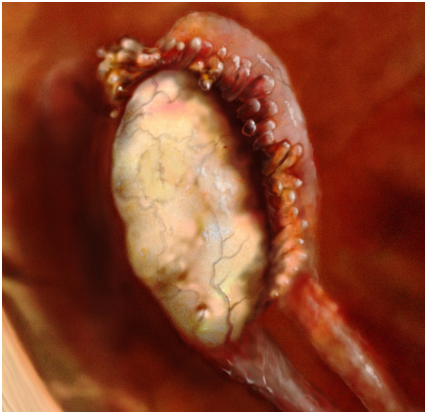




THIS IS **DAY 14 OF YOUR MENSTRUAL CYCLE**
266 days to go

WHAT'S HAPPENING INSIDE

The ovary can be seen here at the end of the Fallopian tube. At around this time of the menstrual cycle, a follicle at the surface of the ovary releases an egg, which is swept into the tube by clearly visible finger-like projections called fimbriae.

“You’re highly likely to ovulate today, if you haven’t already, and if egg meets sperm you may soon be pregnant.”

Typically ovulation occurs around day 14 but it can occur earlier or later. Ovulation is when an egg is released from your ovaries (sometimes two eggs are released—see [Multiple twin pregnancies](#)). LH rises thanks to [estrogen](#) output from the growing follicles, and it is this rise that triggers the events that now take place in the follicle. LH makes the egg inside the follicle become fully mature, ready for release and fertilization. This is the point at which the egg reduces its number of chromosomes (see [Genes through the generations](#)) from 46 to 23.

The follicle is rich with fluid by now. Just before ovulation, it is some 1 in (2.5 cm) or more in diameter. In position, it lies just below the surface of the ovary. If you could see the follicle, it would look like a blister about to burst.

Next the follicle produces enzymes that digest its outer layer, releasing the egg on to the surface of the ovary.

Once the egg has been released from the follicle, it is soon swept into the nearest fallopian tube by the fingerlike projections that form the end of the tube, where it will hopefully be fertilized.

MULTIPLE TWIN PREGNANCIES

If you’ve had nonidentical twins already, your chance of having another set quadruples.

Nonidentical twins occur when more than one follicle ripens completely and the two eggs released at ovulation are both fertilized. The chance of having another set of twins is increased because most women who conceive nonidentical twins (without fertility drugs) show a pattern of releasing more than one egg per cycle. Your chance of having a second set of twins is about 1 in 3,000.

PRESSURE TO CONCEIVE

If you’re trying to conceive, you may have little else on your mind and this can put a strain on your relationship. With the goal of pregnancy in mind, it’s easy to become clinical about sex. At